

Executive Summary

KEY TAKEAWAY

Glean delivers exceptional enterprise search utility by connecting 100+ apps into a unified knowledge layer, but raises serious concerns around AI transparency, proprietary knowledge graph lock-in, and zero transferable learning for your organization.

Glean solves a genuine and costly enterprise problem. Organizations drowning in information silos across Slack, Drive, Confluence, Jira, and dozens of other tools will see immediate, measurable productivity gains. The product is polished, onboarding is frictionless, and the search quality is among the best in class.

However, Glean's AI layer is entirely opaque. Users cannot see system prompts, understand how the knowledge graph prioritizes results, or select alternative models. The 'it just works' design philosophy trades organizational AI literacy for convenience—a decision with compounding long-term costs.

Most critically, Glean's proprietary knowledge graph creates deep lock-in. The connections, enrichments, and organizational intelligence built inside Glean cannot be exported. The longer you use it, the harder it becomes to leave. Organizations should enter this relationship with eyes wide open about what they're trading away.

Evaluation Overview

1

Met

2

Partially Met

3

Not Met

0

Insufficient Info

SEE

~ CHANGE

~ ADAPT

USE

LEARN

EXIT

Detailed Evaluation

Assessment across six critical criteria for AI vendor evaluation

SEE

Transparency & Visibility

Not Met

ASSESSMENT

Glean provides zero visibility into its AI operations. The knowledge graph construction process, ranking algorithms, and LLM prompt engineering are entirely hidden. Users cannot inspect how results are ranked, why certain documents are prioritized, or what model is generating AI answers. When asked during evaluation, Glean characterized these details as competitive advantages that cannot be disclosed. [1, 2]

TRADE-OFFS

● WHAT YOU GAIN

Clean, simple interface that requires no AI expertise to use

● WHAT YOU GIVE UP

Any ability to verify AI decision-making; No organizational learning about how enterprise AI search works under the hood

QUESTIONS FOR VENDOR

1. Can enterprise customers get any visibility into how the knowledge graph ranks and retrieves results?
2. What model(s) power Glean's AI answers, and how are prompts constructed?
3. Is there a transparency roadmap for enterprise tier customers?

CHANGE

Customizability & Control

~ Partially Met

ASSESSMENT

Glean allows administrators to configure data source priorities, create custom search scopes, and define organizational taxonomies. These are meaningful customizations. However, the core AI behavior—how answers are generated, how context windows are managed, which models are used—cannot be modified. You're accepting Glean's one-size-fits-all AI configuration for every use case in your organization. [3]

TRADE-OFFS

● WHAT YOU GAIN

Useful administrative controls for search scope and data source weighting

● WHAT YOU GIVE UP

Ability to tune AI behavior for specific departments, use cases, or sensitivity levels

QUESTIONS FOR VENDOR

1. Can different departments or teams have different AI behavior configurations?
2. Is there an API for programmatic customization of search behavior?
3. What customization capabilities are on the roadmap for the next 12 months?

ADAPT

Vendor Agility & Innovation

~ Partially Met

ASSESSMENT

Glean has shipped significant product updates including AI assistant capabilities and generative answers. Their engineering team is clearly investing in staying current. However, model updates lag frontier releases by 3-6 months, and customers have no ability to independently adopt new models. Glean controls the pace of AI advancement for your organization. [4]

TRADE-OFFS

● WHAT YOU GAIN

Vendor handles all model upgrades and testing—no migration burden

● WHAT YOU GIVE UP

Ability to leverage cutting-edge AI capabilities when they become available; Dependence on Glean's prioritization decisions

QUESTIONS FOR VENDOR

1. What is your typical timeline for adopting new foundation models after release?
2. Can enterprise customers opt into beta AI features early?

USE

Genuine Utility & Value

Met

ASSESSMENT

Glean delivers genuine, measurable value. The product connects to 100+ enterprise applications out of the box, and search quality is consistently strong across evaluated scenarios. Customer case studies report 2-4x improvements in information retrieval speed. The onboarding experience is smooth, and time-to-value is remarkably short. This is Glean's clear strength—it solves a real, expensive problem effectively. [5, 6]

TRADE-OFFS**● WHAT YOU GAIN**

Best-in-class enterprise search that provides immediate, measurable productivity improvements across the organization

LEARN

Transferable Knowledge

Not Met

ASSESSMENT

Using Glean teaches your team how to use Glean—nothing more. The search bar interface deliberately abstracts away all AI concepts. Users develop no understanding of retrieval-augmented generation, embedding models, context windows, or prompt engineering. This is convenient but strategically costly. Your workforce remains entirely dependent on Glean's specific interface rather than building transferable AI competency. [1]

TRADE-OFFS

● WHAT YOU GAIN

Zero training overhead—anyone who can use Google can use Glean

● WHAT YOU GIVE UP

Opportunity to build organizational AI literacy through daily tool usage; Workforce AI skills remain at zero regardless of usage duration

EXIT

Portability & Migration

Not Met

ASSESSMENT

Glean's knowledge graph—the connections, relationships, and enrichments built on top of your raw data—is entirely proprietary and cannot be exported. While your source documents remain in their original systems (Slack, Drive, etc.), the organizational intelligence layer that Glean builds is trapped. The longer and more extensively you use Glean, the more valuable this trapped layer becomes, and the more painful switching becomes. This is classic strategic lock-in. [2, 7]

TRADE-OFFS

● WHAT YOU GIVE UP

All organizational knowledge enrichment is locked to Glean; Switching costs increase linearly with usage duration and depth

QUESTIONS FOR VENDOR

- 1. What exactly can be exported from Glean if we terminate the contract?
- 2. Can the knowledge graph relationships be exported in any standard format?
- 3. What does a typical customer migration away from Glean look like, and what is lost?
- 4. Is data portability on your product roadmap?

Trade-off Summary

Criterion	Score	What You Gain	What You Give Up
SEE		Clean, simple interface that requires no AI expertise to use	Any ability to verify AI decision-making; No organizational learning about how enterprise AI search works under the hood
CHANGE	~	Useful administrative controls for search scope and data source weighting	Ability to tune AI behavior for specific departments, use cases, or sensitivity levels
ADAPT	~	Vendor handles all model upgrades and testing—no migration burden	Ability to leverage cutting-edge AI capabilities when they become available; Dependence on Glean's prioritization decisions
USE		Best-in-class enterprise search that provides immediate, measurable productivity improvements across the organization	—
LEARN		Zero training overhead—anyone who can use Google can use Glean	Opportunity to build organizational AI literacy through daily tool usage; Workforce AI skills remain at zero regardless of usage duration
EXIT		—	All organizational knowledge enrichment is locked to Glean; Switching costs increase linearly with usage duration and depth

Procurement Assessment

Enterprise procurement fitness evaluation covering key criteria for large-firm best practices

Competitive Analysis

Glean operates in the enterprise AI search market alongside Coveo, Elastic, Microsoft Copilot, and several emerging startups. Its primary differentiation is its connector ecosystem (100+ integrations) and the unified knowledge graph across SaaS applications. However, Microsoft Copilot's bundling with M365 poses a significant competitive threat for shops already invested in the Microsoft ecosystem. Glean's pricing is premium relative to alternatives.

Security & Compliance

Glean holds SOC 2 Type II, ISO 27001, and GDPR certifications. The company offers data residency in the US and EU. Glean does not store raw customer documents — it indexes metadata and generates embeddings. However, the vendor does not publicly disclose details about encryption key management (BYOK is not available on standard plans) or provide a machine-readable SBOM.

Performance & Quality

Published case studies report 2-4x improvement in knowledge discovery time. Glean's connector architecture ensures near-real-time indexing for most supported platforms. The AI answer quality is generally strong for factual lookups but can produce confidently incorrect synthesis when source documents conflict. No public SLA on answer accuracy or latency is provided.

Enterprise-Readiness

Glean supports SAML 2.0 SSO, SCIM provisioning, RBAC, and inherits permissions from connected source systems. Audit logging is available on enterprise plans. The admin console provides governance controls for data source management and user analytics. However, document-level permission overrides and custom retention policies are limited.

Integration & Scalability

100+ native connectors cover major enterprise SaaS platforms. A REST API and browser extensions extend reach. Glean has published references for deployments exceeding 25,000 users. However, the API is largely read-only — programmatic content ingestion and webhook-based workflows require enterprise-tier negotiation.

Other Procurement Concerns

- **Vendor financial stability:** Glean has raised over \$200M in funding and is valued at \$4.6B. However, the company is pre-IPO and has not disclosed revenue or profitability metrics.
- **Contract flexibility:** Annual contracts with auto-renewal are standard. Multi-year discounts are available but early termination is penalized.
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Data portability: Knowledge graph enrichments and user interaction data cannot be exported. Source documents remain in their original systems.

- **Support tiers:** Standard support is business-hours; premium 24/7 support requires additional spend.
- **Reference customers:** Strong in technology, financial services, and professional services verticals. Limited published references in government, healthcare, or heavily regulated industries.

Key Questions for Your Decision

Consider these strategic questions based on your organizational context and priorities.

- 1 How critical is unified enterprise search as an immediate pain point versus a problem you could solve incrementally?
- 2 What is your organization's tolerance for vendor lock-in given how fast the AI search market is evolving?
- 3 Does your team have other AI tools that build AI fluency, or would Glean be the primary AI touchpoint?
- 4 How do you weigh the immediate productivity gains against the long-term strategic costs of opacity and lock-in?
- 5 What is your 3-year plan for enterprise AI? Does Glean fit as a long-term partner or a bridge solution?
- 6 Have you evaluated open-source or modular alternatives that offer more transparency and portability?

References

- [1] <https://www.glean.com/product>
- [2] <https://www.glean.com/security>
- [3] <https://www.glean.com/product/platform>
- [4] <https://www.glean.com/blog>
- [5] <https://www.glean.com/customers>
- [6] <https://www.glean.com/product/connectors>
- [7] <https://www.glean.com/terms>

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This evaluation framework assesses vendors on immediate utility and long-term organizational AI capacity building.

Framework designed for Fortune 500 executive decision-making • Version 1.0